

GENDER



BENDERS

Sameer Koli vs Ashwini Kadam

Make 'My Computer' items appear as a bar on the Desktop



Sameer's reservations vanished the moment he sat down at the computer. He right clicked the screen, headed to 'Properties' and scanned in the 'Display Properties' box that popped up. As the search seemed futile, Sameer quickly exited. Next, he right clicked the Taskbar at the bottom of the monitor and clicked Toolbars > New Toolbar > My Computer. However, the Taskbar had been locked and it took him a few more seconds to unlock it and place it on the desktop.



Although she claimed to be not very familiar with computers, Ashwini was game enough to take up the task. Just like Sameer, she began by right-clicking the screen. However, she spent more time scanning each item in the menu. After several unsuccessful attempts, Ashwini moved to the Taskbar. She right-clicked it, opened the menu and selected the icons to create the bar. Ashwini could not unlock it and managed to do so only after it was indicated to her. Still, not bad at all.

only robot out there that can do something as advanced as being a receptionist. There are many practical robots already on duty in Japan. An example is Ligurio, a prototype security robot that can move at 7 kmph on its wheels, and can identify an intruder 50 metres away even at night. It can grab explosives or containers of lethal

chemicals and remove them to safe places.

What makes Asimo's "job" as a receptionist a landmark development of sorts is that this indicates we're getting closer to seeing robots as personal companions. As we mentioned in *I, Robot—Your Friend*, Digit September 2005, it's been predicted that robots will walk the streets by 2010. We

mentioned in the article that it sounded "rather impossible." But if, in 2006, we are already seeing robots as receptionists, who's now to say that's a far-fetched prediction?

25 MILLION TO 38.5

Internet Penetration Increases

You'd have expected Internet penetration in India to have increased, but we have the figures. It remains relatively very low, but has soared 54 per cent over the course of 2005 to 38.5 million, and will jump to 100 million in two years, according to a IMAI (Internet and Mobile Association of India) study. In comparison, China already has 100 million Internet users, according to government statistics.

With increased Internet penetration comes more e-commerce; as of now, the e-commerce market is estimated at Rs 1,180 crore. It's estimated to grow to Rs 2,300 crores in 2006-07.

Dayanidhi Maran, Union Minister for IT and telecommunications said about these growth figures, "We have ambitious goals regarding Internet access and are providing all support to attain them. The Government is making concerted efforts with a clear emphasis on the importance of affordable broadband... Our aim is to achieve critical mass across the country with a special

impetus in rural and remote areas."

According to Preeti Desai, president of the IMAI, "E-mail and chat have become a 'ubiquitous' part of online Indians' daily routine, and online banking, bill payment, stock trading, job searches, and matrimonial searches have seen 'tremendous' rise in usage."

Unfortunately, the fact remains that it's mostly urban India that's online. In fact, urban India taken as a separate entity has one of the highest Internet penetration rates in the world, while the overall rate for India stands at just about two per cent. Urban India is hankering for broadband, while rural India is still to be educated about the possibilities the Internet opens up.

How long this stark, uncomfortable contrast will last is anybody's guess.

USE A THIEF TO CATCH A THIEF

"Honeypot" Could Help Counter Viruses

The problem of computer viruses won't go away anytime soon. But a new mathematical study by Eran Shir at Israel's Tel Aviv University shows that you can tackle the virus problem using a cure that itself spreads in a viral fashion, and, as a result "immunises" the entire Internet.

Virtualisation

While Virtualisation—partitioning your computer into two or more 'virtual machines' to run multiple software simultaneously—is not really a new concept, Intel has brought it back in the news by announcing its support for virtualisation at the chip level. Virtualised machines can handle the load of many under-utilised machines, saving the cost of buying a whole new set of hardware.

Thus far, virtualisation was done only through software such as VMware, but now with hardware support for Virtual Machine Monitors, Intel will take the performance of such software to new heights. Virtualisation has been used in servers for a while now and Intel hopes to bring it to desktop PCs as well, with two new virtualisation-enabled Pentium 4 processors ready for shipping.

Buzzword
of the MONTH